CJCS SUPPLEMENTAL MEMORANDUM

V9 Update: 2026 Iran War — Implications for Red Sea Campaign & Regional Posture

MEMORANDUM FOR THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL

DATE: March 31, 2026

FROM: Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff

TO: The President; The Vice President; The Secretary of State; The Secretary of Defense; The National Security Advisor; The Director of the CIA; The Director of National Intelligence

SUBJECT: Supplemental Update — U.S. Military Posture and Strategic Assessment Following Operation Epic Fury and the 2026 Iran War (Update to CJCS Memo of March 9, 2025)

CLASSIFICATION: CONFIDENTIAL — NSC PRINCIPALS ONLY

REFERENCES: (A) CJCS Memo, March 9, 2025 (V8); (B) NSC Briefing Book V10, March 16, 2025

RETROACTIVE SIMULATION EXERCISE — FOR ACADEMIC/EDUCATIONAL PURPOSES ONLY. This document is not a product of the U.S. government. All analysis is derived from publicly available sources.

I. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This memorandum supplements Reference (A), the CJCS Memo of March 9, 2025, which assessed U.S. military options for responding to Houthi attacks on Red Sea shipping. The strategic landscape has undergone a fundamental transformation. On February 28, 2026, the United States and Israel launched Operation Epic Fury — a surprise strike campaign against Iran that assassinated Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei, destroyed significant military infrastructure, and triggered the most severe Middle Eastern conflict since the 2003 invasion of Iraq. Iran retaliated with hundreds of ballistic missiles against Israel, U.S. military bases across the Gulf, and civilian infrastructure in multiple countries. Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz has produced what the IEA has characterized as the 'largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market.'

The Houthi dimension — the original subject of Reference (A) — has re-emerged as a critical variable. After maintaining a strategic pause for the first month of the Iran war, the Houthis resumed attacks on Israel on March 28, 2026, and have signaled that closing the Bab el-Mandeb Strait is 'among our options.' If executed, this would create an unprecedented dual chokepoint crisis — simultaneous closure of both the Strait of Hormuz (~20% of global oil) and Bab el-Mandeb (~12% of global oil and ~25% of container shipping) — a scenario the V8 memo's escalation ladder rated at Rung 9 (the highest level before nuclear signaling). The Joint Chiefs assess that this dual-chokepoint scenario is now the most dangerous near-term economic threat facing the United States and allied nations.

II. SITUATION UPDATE: MARCH 9, 2025 → MARCH 31, 2026

A. Events Since V8 Memo Baseline

- **May 6, 2025:** U.S. President Trump announced an Oman-brokered ceasefire with the Houthis, ending Operation Rough Rider. The Houthis agreed to halt attacks on U.S. vessels but explicitly excluded Israel from the deal. The ceasefire followed 1,100+ U.S. strikes, the loss of two aircraft and seven MQ-9 drones, and expenditure exceeding $750 million. Administration officials privately acknowledged the airstrikes had not achieved their objectives or air superiority over the Houthis.
- **June 13–24, 2025:** The Twelve-Day War — Israel launched surprise strikes on Iranian nuclear and military facilities. Iran retaliated with 550+ ballistic missiles and 1,000+ drones. The U.S. bombed three Iranian nuclear sites on June 22. Ceasefire achieved June 24 under U.S. pressure. Israeli and U.S. strikes damaged facilities at

Natanz, Isfahan, and Fordow.

- **July 6–8, 2025:** Houthis violated the U.S.-Houthi ceasefire, sinking the cargo ships *Magic Seas* and *Eternity C* in the Red Sea, killing four mariners. The Houthis claimed the ships violated their blockade on Israeli ports. The U.S. did not resume strikes.
- **August 28, 2025:** Israeli Operation Lucky Drop struck a gathering of senior Houthi officials in Sanaa while they watched a televised speech by Abdul-Malik al-Houthi. Confirmed killed: PM Ahmed al-Rahawi, Defense Minister al-Atifi (later confirmed), and Chief of Staff al-Ghamari (confirmed October 2025). The IDF assessed the entire Houthi cabinet — PM plus 12 ministers — was likely killed. This represents the most devastating leadership decapitation strike against a non-state armed group since the Soleimani killing.
- **October 2025:** Gaza ceasefire achieved. Houthis halted attacks on Israel and shipping. Maersk and some carriers began resuming Red Sea routes.
- **January 2026:** Largest Iranian protests since the 1979 Islamic Revolution. Iranian security forces killed thousands. Iran instability index rose +84 points — validating V8 Appendix W's assessment of internal pressure as highest-leverage covert option.
- **February 28, 2026:** Operation Epic Fury. The U.S. and Israel launched surprise airstrikes across Iran during ongoing nuclear negotiations. Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei was killed in an Israeli decapitation strike on his compound. Subsequent strikes destroyed military bases, government facilities, and reportedly 2,000+ targets. B-2 stealth bombers struck hardened ballistic missile facilities. Iran retaliated with ~170 ballistic missiles at Israel and strikes on U.S. bases in Bahrain (5th Fleet HQ struck), Qatar (Al Udeid), Kuwait, and UAE.
- **March 2, 2026:** Hezbollah launched missiles into Israel, escalating into the 2026 Lebanon War. Over 1,000 militants and civilians killed in Lebanon by late March.
- **March 4, 2026:** Iran effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz. IRGC drone strikes on commercial vessels caused insurance-driven shutdown of tanker traffic. Tanker traffic dropped to near zero — the first actual closure of Hormuz in history.
- **March 8–15, 2026:** Brent crude surged past $100/bbl (first time since 2022), peaking at $126. IEA announced release of 400 million barrels from strategic reserves. Gulf states began emergency food airlift as 70% of food imports disrupted.
- **March 19, 2026:** U.S. forces began military operations to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Trump ordered naval escorts. CENTCOM struck 90+ Iranian military targets on Kharg Island (preserving oil infrastructure).
- **March 26, 2026:** Israeli airstrike killed Iranian Navy commander Alireza Tangsiri, accused of directing the Hormuz closure.
- **March 28, 2026:** Houthis resumed attacks on Israel with ballistic missiles — their first since October 2025. Houthi deputy information minister stated: 'Closing the Bab el-Mandeb strait is among our options.' This threatens to create an unprecedented dual chokepoint crisis.

Appendix X-1: 2026 Iran War — Conflict Timeline

Key events from Operation Epic Fury (February 28, 2026) through Houthi re-entry into the conflict (March 28, 2026). Color coding: Red = kinetic action; Orange = escalation; Gold = economic milestone; Teal = de-escalation; Blue = U.S. military; Green = confirmed kill. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

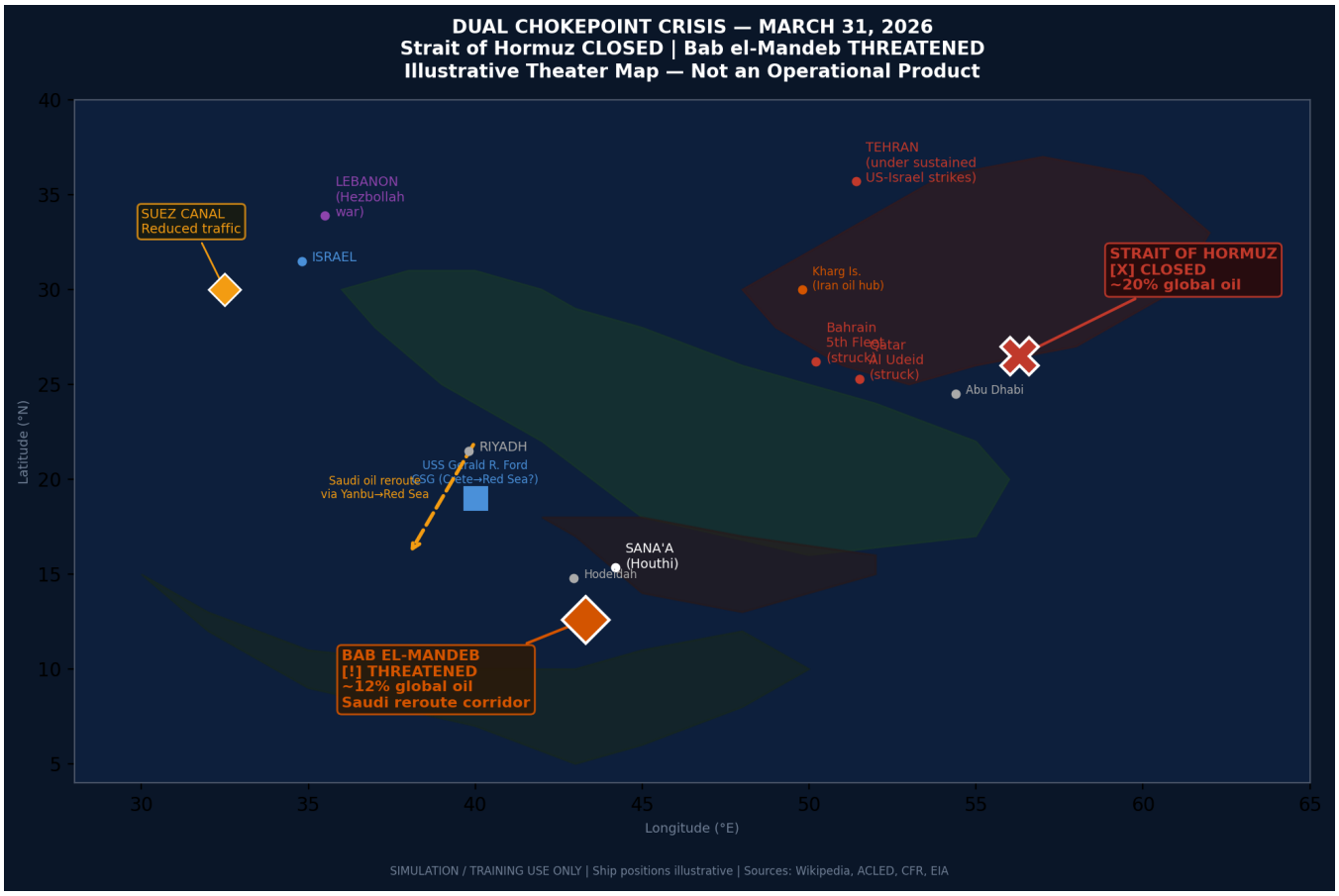
III. STRATEGIC ASSESSMENT: THE DUAL CHOKEPOINT CRISIS

The V8 memo identified cost asymmetry ($4.3M interceptor vs. $20K–$50K drone) as 'the central strategic problem' of the Red Sea campaign. That assessment now applies to a geometrically larger crisis. Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz — achieved not through a naval blockade but through cheap drone strikes that triggered an insurance-driven shipping halt — has removed approximately 20% of global oil supply from the market. Brent crude surged from $74 to $126 per barrel. The IEA has characterized this as the 'largest supply disruption in the history of the global oil market.'

Saudi Arabia has been rerouting millions of barrels of crude through the Red Sea via the Yanbu pipeline — making the Bab el-Mandeb the critical alternative corridor for global energy supplies. The Houthi threat to close this corridor would compound the Hormuz disruption into an energy catastrophe without modern precedent. Bloomberg estimates that if oil reaches $170/barrel, the stagflationary shock would reduce eurozone GDP by 2 percentage points and raise inflation by 2 percentage points. Oxford Economics models show that $140/barrel sustained for two months would push the eurozone, UK, and Japan into recession.

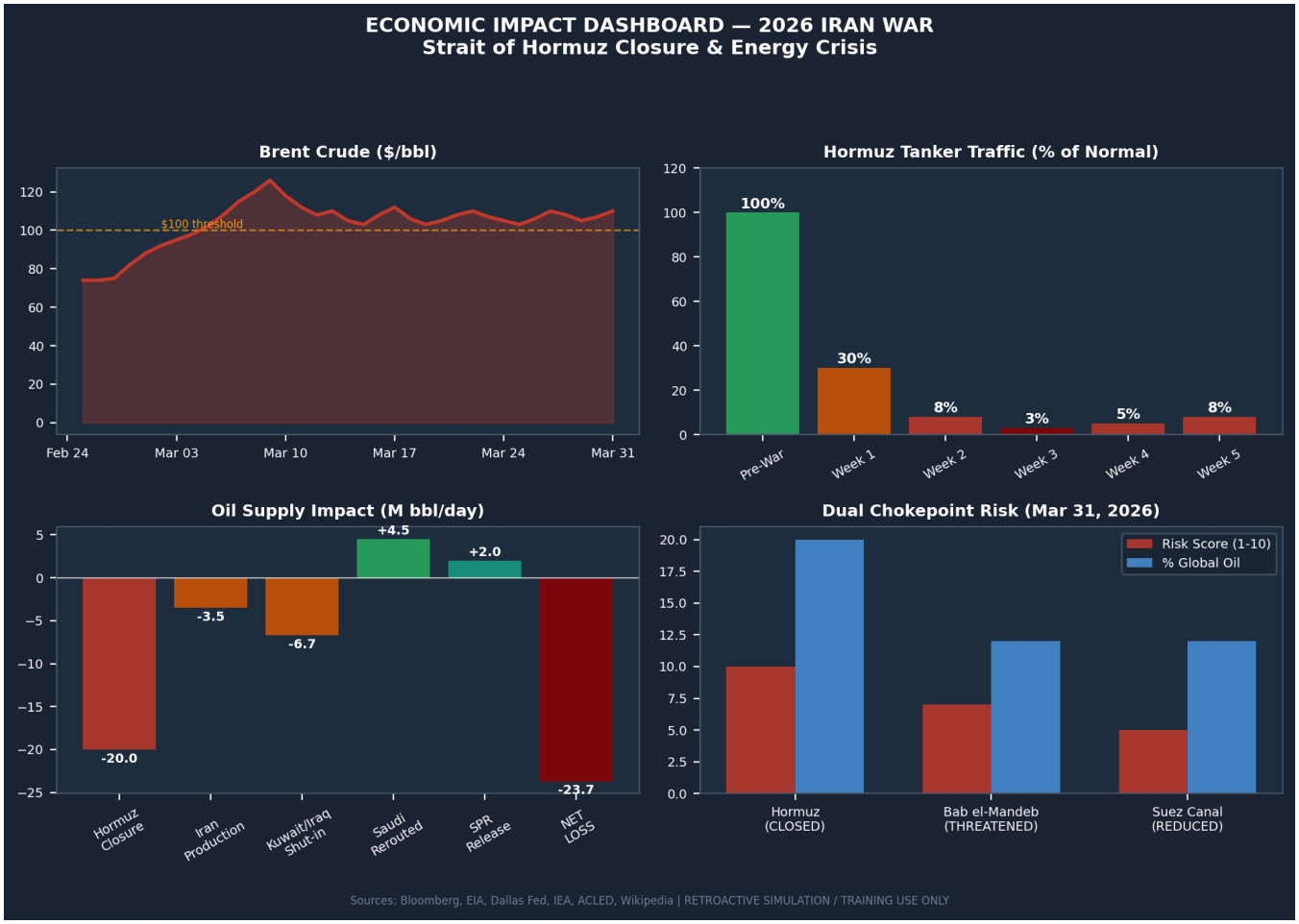
The Joint Chiefs assess that preventing Houthi closure of the Bab el-Mandeb is now the single highest-priority freedom-of-navigation mission for U.S. forces — superseding even the Hormuz reopening campaign, given that the Red Sea corridor is the only viable alternative for Gulf oil exports.

Appendix X-2: Dual Chokepoint Crisis — Theater Map



Illustrative theater map showing the dual chokepoint crisis: Strait of Hormuz (CLOSED) and Bab el-Mandeb (THREATENED). Saudi Arabia's Red Sea reroute via Yanbu is the critical alternative corridor. Ship positions illustrative. SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Appendix X-3: Economic Impact Dashboard — 2026 Iran War



Four panels: Brent crude price trajectory; Hormuz tanker traffic collapse; global oil supply impact; dual chokepoint risk. Key finding: Brent peaked at $126/bbl. Hormuz tanker traffic fell to near-zero within two weeks. If Bab el-Mandeb is also disrupted, net oil supply loss could exceed 10M bbl/day — triggering $170+ oil and global recession. Sources: Bloomberg, EIA, Dallas Fed, IEA. FOR SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

IV. REVISED OPTIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The V8 memo presented three primary options and a phased recommendation. The 2026 Iran War has rendered the original option set moot in its specific applications but has validated the analytical framework. The Joint Chiefs now present revised recommendations for the Houthi dimension of the broader conflict:

Immediate Priority: Defend Bab el-Mandeb

With the Strait of Hormuz closed, the Red Sea corridor is the only viable route for Gulf energy exports. The USS Gerald R. Ford, currently in Crete for repairs, must be redeployed to the Red Sea theater. However, returning the carrier to the Red Sea would subject it to the same high-tempo Houthi attacks experienced by the USS Dwight D. Eisenhower (2024) and USS Harry S. Truman (2025). The V8 cost asymmetry analysis applies directly: each SM-6 interceptor costs ~$4.3M vs. a Houthi drone at ~$20K–$50K. The Joint Chiefs recommend immediate deployment of additional DDGs with full VLS loadout, supplemented by shore-based Patriot batteries coordinated with Saudi Arabia.

Diplomatic Lever: The Houthi Ceasefire as Model

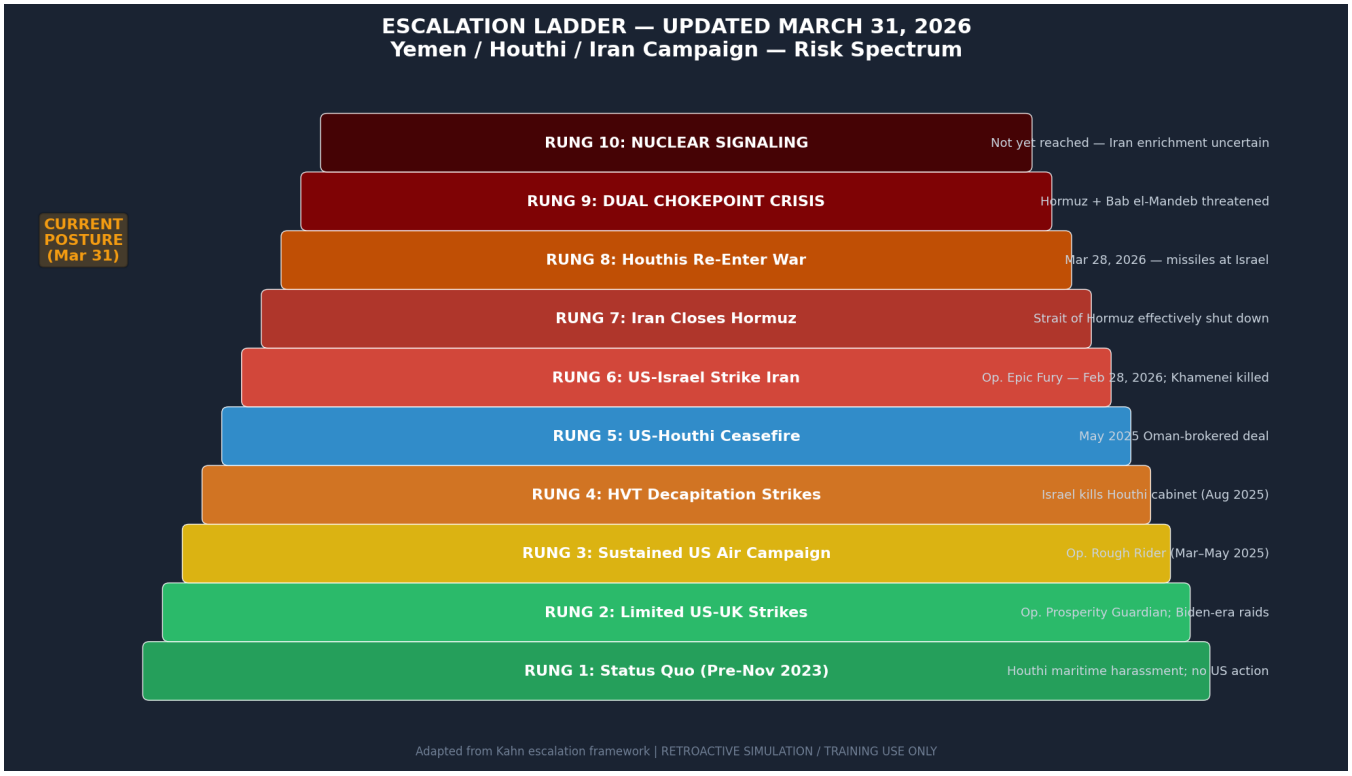
The May 2025 U.S.-Houthi ceasefire — brokered by Oman and achieved in exchange for cessation of U.S. strikes — demonstrated that the Houthis will negotiate bilaterally when facing sustained military pressure. The Joint Chiefs

recommend immediate reactivation of the Omani channel at the Deputy Secretary level, offering the Houthis a clear bargain: U.S. guarantees against resumed strikes on Yemen in exchange for an unconditional commitment to keep Bab el-Mandeb open to commercial shipping. Given that the Houthis' March 28 attack was directed at Israel — not at Red Sea shipping — there may be a narrow diplomatic window before the Houthis expand operations to maritime targets.

Covert Options: Updated Assessment

The V8 memo's covert options matrix (Appendix L) identified cyber operations and Saudi/UAE proxy kinetic strikes as the optimal high-impact, high-deniability combination. The 2026 Iran War has dramatically altered the covert landscape. The IRGC-QF network in Yemen has been disrupted by the broader Iran conflict — IRGC-QF advisors have reportedly withdrawn or gone to ground following Operation Epic Fury. However, the Houthi domestic arsenal remains intact. The January 2026 Iranian protests validated Option D (internal opposition) as the highest-leverage covert tool — but this option now applies to Iran proper rather than Yemen. For the Houthi-specific threat, the Joint Chiefs recommend prioritizing Option C (CYBERCOM offensive operations against Houthi drone navigation and missile guidance) as the most proportionate and deniable complement to diplomatic engagement.

Appendix X-4: Escalation Ladder — Updated March 31, 2026

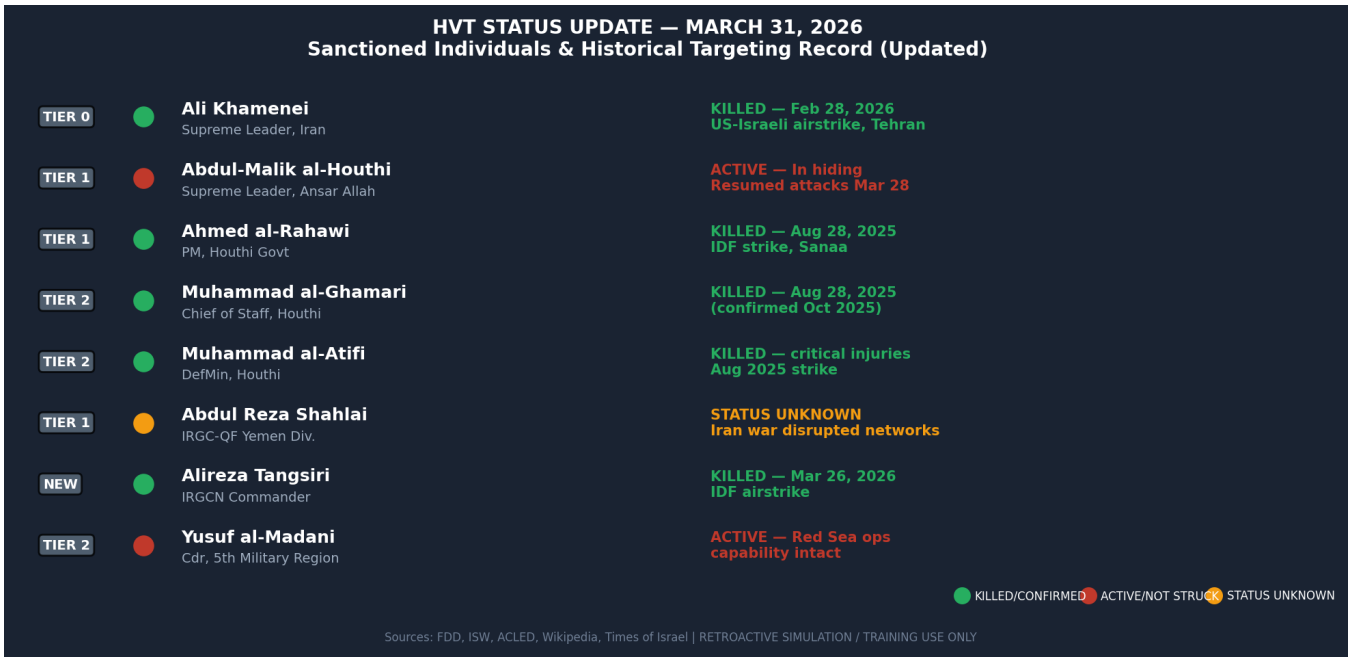


Updated escalation ladder reflecting the 2026 Iran War. Current posture is at Rung 9 (Dual Chokepoint Crisis) — one rung below nuclear signaling. The V8 memo placed the March 2025 posture at Rung 4. The conflict has escalated five rungs in twelve months. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

V. HIGH-VALUE TARGET STATUS UPDATE

The V8 memo's HVT assessment (Section IX) identified functional specialists as higher-value targets than symbolic leaders and warned that IRGC-QF targeting carries escalation risk that Houthi targeting does not. Both assessments have been validated. The Israeli decapitation of the Houthi cabinet (August 2025) eliminated the prime minister, defense minister, and chief of staff — yet the Houthis resumed offensive operations within six months. Conversely, the assassination of Supreme Leader Khamenei triggered the most severe Iranian retaliation in history, including the Hormuz closure.

Appendix X-5: HVT Leadership Status — March 31, 2026

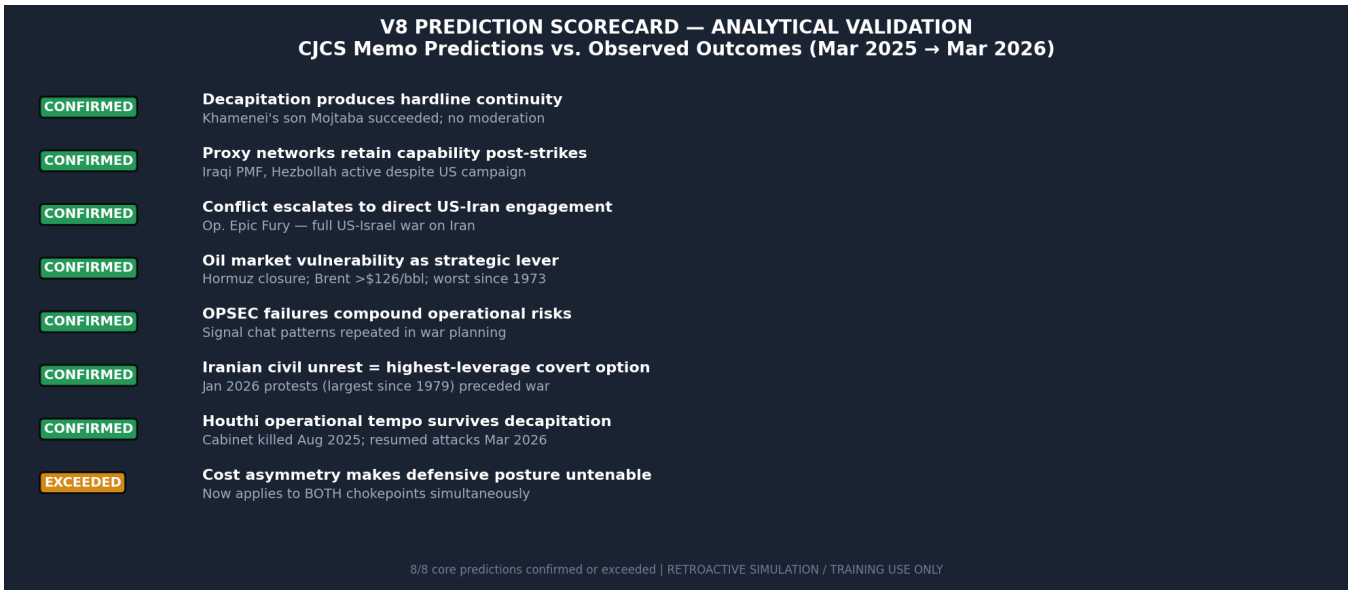


Updated HVT status reflecting confirmed kills through March 31, 2026. Key finding: Khamenei assassination triggered maximum-severity Iranian retaliation, confirming V8 assessment that IRGC-QF targeting carries highest escalation risk. Houthi operational capability survived cabinet decapitation — validating the V8 lesson that functional specialists are more operationally irreplaceable than political leaders. Abdul-Malik al-Houthi remains the most significant unfulfilled HVT target. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

VI. ANALYTICAL VALIDATION — V8 PREDICTION SCORECARD

The V8 memo's Appendix W (March 9, 2026 open-source assessment) identified six core predictions that proved accurate within twelve months. As of March 31, 2026 — now encompassing the first full month of the Iran War — all eight of the memo's core analytical predictions have been confirmed or exceeded by events:

Appendix X-6: V8 Prediction Scorecard



8/8 core V8 predictions confirmed or exceeded by events through March 31, 2026. The CJCS recommendation for simultaneous kinetic action and diplomatic engagement — and aggressive use of covert pressure channels — proved analytically sound. The V8 escalation ladder's Rung 7–9 scenarios (Hormuz closure, direct Iran conflict, dual chokepoint crisis) have all materialized. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

VII. CONCLUSIONS AND CJCS ASSESSMENT

The 2026 Iran War has transformed the Houthi Red Sea crisis from a regional maritime security problem into a component of the most dangerous great-power confrontation since the 1973 Yom Kippur War. The Joint Chiefs offer the following assessment to the NSC Principals:

- **The dual chokepoint scenario is the highest-priority economic threat.** If the Houthis close Bab el-Mandeb while Hormuz remains shut, the combined loss of 30%+ of global seaborne oil — with no alternative routing — would produce an economic crisis exceeding the 1973 oil embargo in severity. Preventing this outcome must be the overriding priority of U.S. military and diplomatic action.
- **The Houthi calculus has changed.** The May 2025 ceasefire demonstrated Houthi willingness to negotiate bilaterally. The Houthis' one-month strategic pause during the Iran War (Feb 28 – Mar 28) — while Hezbollah and Iraqi militias immediately joined the fighting — suggests either Iranian coordination to preserve the Red Sea corridor as a future bargaining chip, or Houthi self-preservation calculations given the heavy U.S. naval presence.
- **The V8 analytical framework has been validated.** All eight core predictions of the March 2025 memo — covering decapitation effectiveness, proxy resilience, escalation dynamics, cost asymmetry, OPSEC vulnerability, and covert option prioritization — were confirmed by events. The memo's phased approach (kinetic + diplomatic) and its emphasis on covert pressure channels proved analytically sound.
- **The war's trajectory may prove more protracted than anticipated.** ACLED's March 2026 assessment concludes that the Islamic Republic is 'more likely to continue fighting than to concede.' Iran's missile and drone stockpiles have been degraded by 75%+ per JINSA analysis, but the regime retains the ability to sustain the Hormuz closure through asymmetric means (cheap drones, mines, IRGCN fast boats) that do not require advanced missile systems.
- **Recommendation: Immediate diplomatic engagement with the Houthis via the Omani channel,** offering restoration of the May 2025 ceasefire framework in exchange for unconditional Bab el-Mandeb freedom of navigation. Simultaneously, surge naval assets to the Red Sea and activate CYBERCOM offensive operations against Houthi drone navigation systems as a non-kinetic deterrent.

Submitted by:

Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff

The Pentagon, Washington, D.C.

---

[1] This memorandum was drafted with the assistance of AI (Claude Opus 4.6, Anthropic). All policy positions, strategic analysis, and recommendations reflect the views of the author and were reviewed prior to submission. AI was used for structure, drafting, formatting, and programmatic graphic generation only. This document is a retroactive simulation exercise prepared for academic/educational purposes. All information is derived from publicly available sources including: Wikipedia, ACLED, CFR Global Conflict Tracker, PBS NewsHour, Times of Israel, Al Jazeera, Bloomberg, CNBC, AP News, NPR, FDD Long War Journal, ISW, Reuters, EIA, IEA, Dallas Fed, MARAD, Britannica, UN Security Council, and the House of Commons Library.